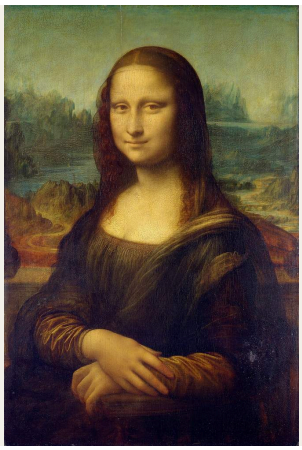
PARIS, FRANCE

Louvre: Masterpieces

Twenty paintings to help you find your own way into the collection.



The young man in Georges de La Tour's card game can see his hand, but not the extra card behind his opponent's back. We have a better view of his predicament than he does. Across the collection, painters keep changing our position: close enough to watch a woman making lace, beneath an immense wedding feast, or at the edge of a raft whose passengers may never be rescued.

These twenty works offer different places to begin. Some need their stories explained; others become interesting through a small adjustment of attention. A painted letter, a lowered hand or a patch of bare table can be enough. There is no need to treat every picture as a puzzle with one correct answer.

The order below follows the site's selection, not the museum's rooms. Choose a handful for a visit, or compare them here: David's two Roman scenes disagree about what heroism looks like, while Raphael and Rembrandt find very different ways to give a face weight and presence. The quieter pictures deserve time too. Chardin's kitchen is no less carefully constructed than Veronese's banquet.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/louvre

The selection · 20

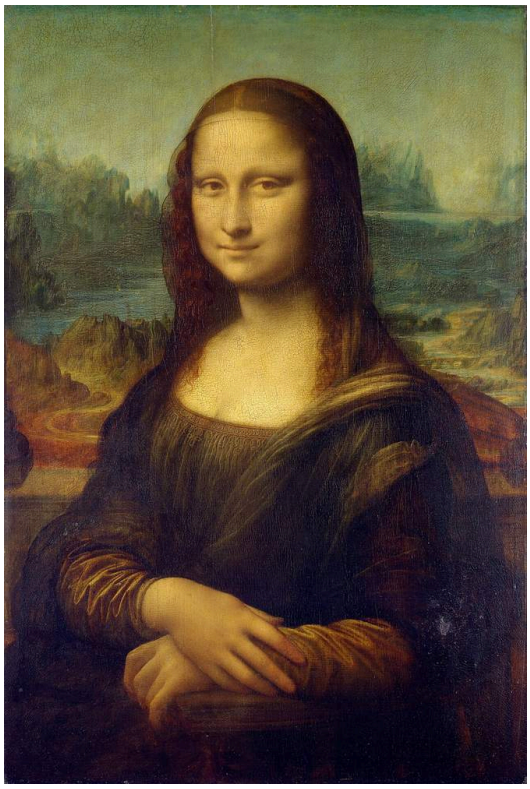
1. Mona Lisa
   Leonardo da Vinci · 1503–1519
2. The Lacemaker
   Johannes Vermeer · c. 1669–1670
3. Liberty Leading the People
   Eugène Delacroix · 1830
4. The Raft of the Medusa
   Théodore Géricault · 1818–1819
5. The Wedding at Cana
   Paolo Veronese · 1562–1563
6. The Intervention of the Sabine Women
   Jacques-Louis David · 1799
7. The Cheat with the Ace of Diamonds
   Georges de La Tour · c. 1636–1640
8. La Grande Odalisque
   Jean-Auguste-Dominique Ingres · 1814
9. Baldassare Castiglione
   Raphael · c. 1514–1515
10. Pierrot, formerly called Gilles
    Jean-Antoine Watteau · c.1718 - c. 1719
11. The Virgin of Chancellor Rolin
    Jan van Eyck · c. 1430–1435
12. The Oath of the Horatii
    Jacques-Louis David · dated 1784; completed 1785
13. The Death of Sardanapalus
    Eugène Delacroix · 1827
14. Imaginary View of the Grande Galerie in Ruins
    Hubert Robert · 1796
15. The Virgin and Child in Majesty with Six Angels
    Cimabue · 1275–1300
16. La Belle Jardinière
    Raphael · 1507
17. Self-Portrait at the Easel
    Rembrandt van Rijn · 1660
18. Bathsheba at Her Bath
    Rembrandt van Rijn · 1654
19. The Ray
    Jean-Baptiste-Siméon Chardin · 1728
20. Ship of Fools
    Hieronymus Bosch · 1475/1500

01 / 20

Mona Lisa

Leonardo da Vinci

1503–1519 · Oil on poplar panel · Musée du Louvre



Leonardo da Vinci. Portrait de Lisa Gherardini, épouse de Francesco del Giocondo, dit La Joconde ou Monna Lisa. Image credit: Leonardo da Vinci; Source credit: Cropped and relevelled from File:Mona Lisa, by Leonardo da Vinci, from C2RMF.jpg . Originally C2RMF: Galerie de tableaux en très haute définition : image page. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

The folded hands make a steady base for a face that is much harder to read. At the corners of Lisa Gherardini's mouth, shadow softens the boundary between skin and lip. Leonardo's *sfumato*, the gradual blending of tones, leaves us without the clear outlines we normally use to judge an expression.

Then look behind her. Roads and water wind into a landscape whose distant forms lose their sharpness. The portrait's stillness depends partly on that contrast: hands and chair close to us, a world receding beyond them. The smile need not yield a secret for the painting to remain absorbing.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: INV 779

02 / 20

The Lacemaker

Johannes Vermeer

c. 1669–1670 · Oil on canvas mounted on wood · Musée du Louvre



Johannes Vermeer. La Dentellière. Image credit: Johannes Vermeer; Source credit: Musée du Louvre. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

At just 24 by 21 centimetres, this is a painting that asks for a change of pace. The woman's lowered eyes and busy fingers draw attention to a very small area. The red and white threads nearer us are surprisingly blurred; proximity does not bring clarity.

Lacemaking could signify domestic virtue in Vermeer's time, and the Louvre identifies the sitter as a woman of comfortable circumstances rather than a professional worker. Yet the immediate subject is concentration. There is barely enough room in the picture for anything beyond her task. Compare that enclosure with the space surrounding Lisa Gherardini.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MI 1448

03 / 20

Liberty Leading the People

Eugène Delacroix

1830 · Oil on canvas · Musée du Louvre



Eugène Delacroix. Le 28 juillet 1830. La Liberté guidant le peuple. Image credit: Eugène Delacroix; Source credit: photo Shonagon 2024-05-02. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

The date is 1830: this is the July Revolution, not the French Revolution of 1789. Delacroix brings an allegorical figure into the fighting. Liberty carries a real weapon and steps over real-looking corpses, but her exposed breast, raised flag and commanding scale set her apart from the people beside her.

The advance seems irresistible until attention reaches the foreground. Bodies lie across the path the living must take. The picture can celebrate an uprising and still make its cost difficult to avoid. Notice how the flag lifts the eye while the dead bring it back down.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RF 129

04 / 20

The Raft of the Medusa

Théodore Géricault

1818–1819 · Oil on canvas · Musée du Louvre



Théodore Géricault. Le radeau de la Méduse. Image credit: Théodore Géricault; Source credit: Unknown source Unknown source. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

Find the ship on the horizon before following the bodies across the raft. It is so small that the survivors' gestures seem almost useless. Géricault builds their effort upwards, from the dead and exhausted in front to the raised cloth at the far end. Hope has a direction, but no guarantee.

The wreck occurred in 1816 and became a public scandal. In 1819, Géricault gave a recent catastrophe the scale normally reserved for grand historical subjects. His passengers are caught before the outcome is secure. Knowing that rescue was possible does not make that painted distance feel any shorter.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: INV 4884

05 / 20

The Wedding at Cana

Paolo Veronese

1562–1563 · Oil on canvas · Musée du Louvre



Paul Véronèse. Les Noces de Cana. Image: WikiArt. Domaine public. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Domaine public

It is easy to lose Christ in the crowd. He sits near the centre, beneath the activity on the terrace, while musicians, servants and guests fill almost ten metres of painted canvas. The biblical miracle is the transformation of water into wine; Veronese surrounds it with the business of a splendid meal.

Painted in 1562–1563 for the Benedictine refectory of San Giorgio Maggiore in Venice, the picture originally faced people who were themselves eating. Its architecture and long tables make sense in that setting. Christ's relative stillness becomes easier to find once the surrounding bustle has had its turn.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: INV 142

06 / 20

The Intervention of the Sabine Women

Jacques-Louis David

1799 · Oil on canvas · Musée du Louvre



Jacques-Louis David. Les Sabines. Image credit: Jacques-Louis David. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

The woman in white steps into the space where the weapons are about to meet. She is Hersilia, caught between her Roman husband and her Sabine father. The women have family on both sides of the conflict; the children at their feet make that relationship impossible to ignore.

David makes the interruption the painting's decisive action. Outstretched arms hold the centre, while armed men hesitate around them. Compare it with *The Oath of the Horatii*: there, men reach for swords; here, a woman breaks their momentum. Classical bodies and Roman stories can support very different accounts of courage.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: INV 3691

07 / 20

The Cheat with the Ace of Diamonds

Georges de La Tour

c. 1636–1640 · Oil on canvas · Musée du Louvre



Georges de la Tour. The Cheat with the Ace of Diamonds. Image: WikiArt. Public domain. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain

The cheating is visible before the game is understood. At the left, a player reaches behind his back for a card. The richly dressed young man opposite studies his own hand. Between them, a glance and a pointing finger suggest that the other participants know more than he does.

Follow those small signals across the table. Almost nothing moves, yet an entire scheme becomes legible. La Tour gives the spectator an uncomfortable advantage: we can identify the deception without stopping it. The painting's tension lies in the short interval before the young man discovers what we already know.

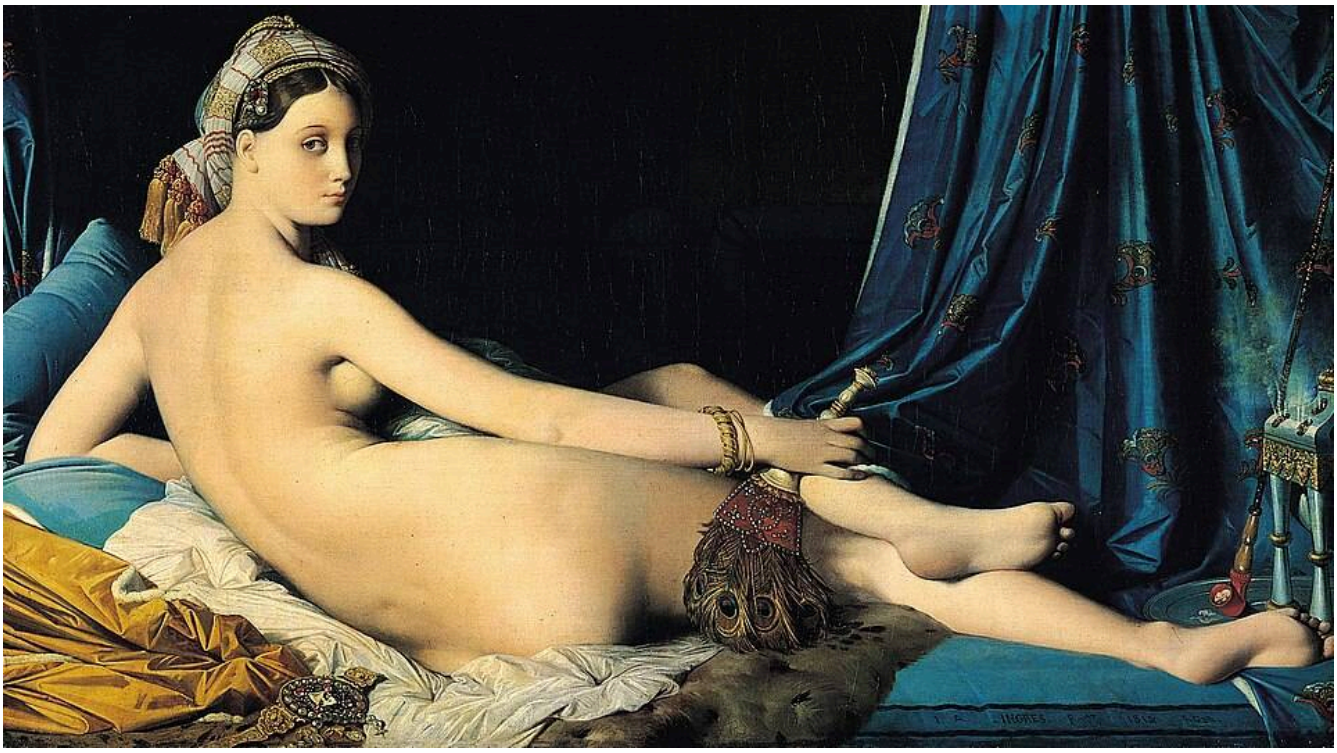
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RF 1972 8

08 / 20

La Grande Odalisque

Jean-Auguste-Dominique Ingres

1814 · Oil on canvas · Musée du Louvre



Jean-Auguste-Dominique Ingres. Une odalisque, dite La grande odalisque. Image credit: Jean-Auguste-Dominique Ingres; Source credit: wartburg.edu. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

Follow the long sweep from the woman's shoulder to her hip. The back extends farther than ordinary anatomy would allow, but the line connects smoothly with the turn of her head and the surrounding fabric. Ingres has made a convincing arrangement from an implausible body.

The peacock fan, turban and luxurious textiles place her in an imagined harem. This is a European fantasy of an interior, not a reliable account of Ottoman life. The polished surface is part of that construction: everything appears available for inspection, while the woman returns a look that is harder to interpret.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RF 1158

09 / 20

Baldassare Castiglione

Raphael

c. 1514–1515 · Musée du Louvre



Raphaël. Portrait de Baldassare Castiglione. Image: WikiArt. Domaine public. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Domaine public

Grey fur, a black cap and a pale shirt leave little competition for Castiglione's face. His hands rest low in the frame; his blue eyes meet ours without an emphatic gesture. Raphael gives a writer and diplomat a presence that seems remarkably unforced.

That apparent ease is carefully arranged. The shoulder turns one way, the face another, and the broad shapes of the clothes hold the figure together. Beside the *Mona Lisa*, this is another portrait in which folded hands and restrained movement do more than elaborate props could. The Louvre dates it to about 1514–1515.

Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

Pierrot, formerly called Gilles

Jean-Antoine Watteau

c.1718 - c. 1719 · Musée du Louvre



Antoine Watteau. Pierrot. Image: WikiArt. Domaine public. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Domaine public

Pierrot has the costume of a comic performer and very little to perform. He stands frontally, arms hanging, in white clothes that make him conspicuous against the landscape. His companions appear lower in the picture, as though they belong to an action from which he has become detached.

It is tempting to call him sad and leave it there. But the still face gives less away than that description suggests. Watteau leaves a gap between a recognisable theatrical role and the person occupying it. The awkward pause is the part of the performance that remains with us.

Object source · Open artwork

11 / 20

The Virgin of Chancellor Rolin

Jan van Eyck

c. 1430–1435 · Musée du Louvre



Jan van Eyck. La Vierge du chancelier Rolin. Image: WikiArt. Domaine public. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Domaine public

Nicolas Rolin kneels opposite the Virgin and Child as if they share an exceptionally well-appointed room. His patterned robe, clasped hands and concentrated face receive as much care as the sacred figures. An angel raises a crown above Mary, while the arches open onto a river and a densely inhabited town.

Rolin was chancellor to the duke of Burgundy. The image gives his devotion a very public form: he is permanently present at an encounter unavailable to ordinary visitors. Van Eyck makes the imagined meeting persuasive through particulars, right down to the small buildings beyond the room.

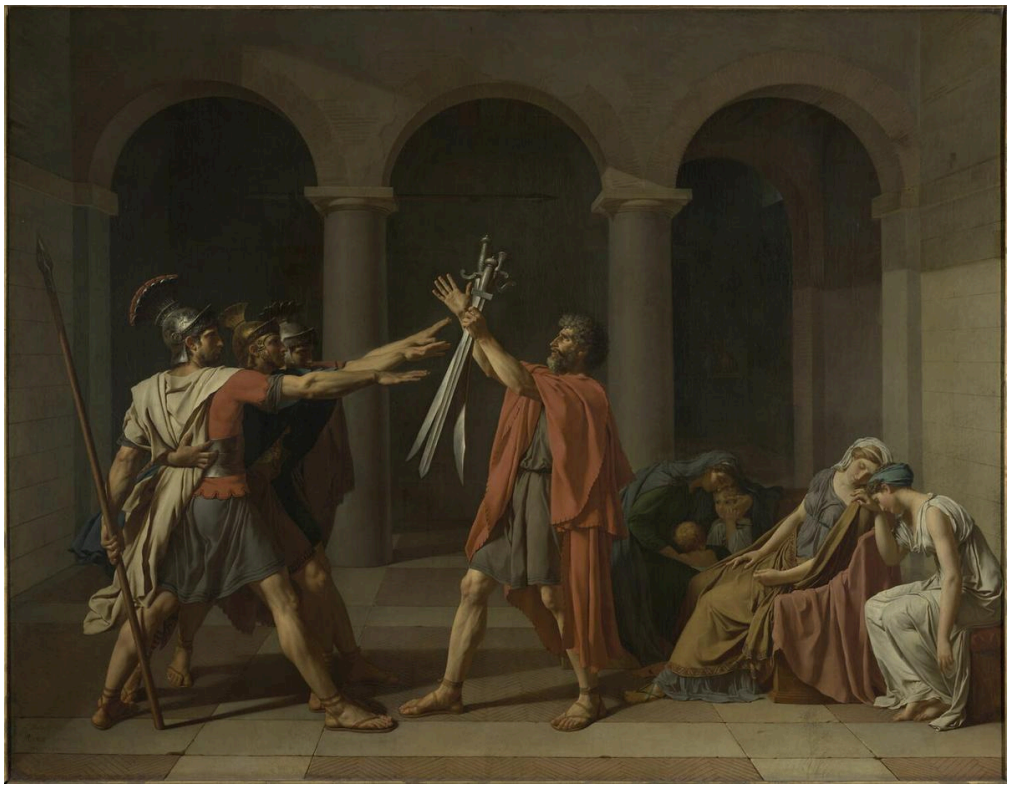
Object source · Open artwork

12 / 20

The Oath of the Horatii

Jacques-Louis David

dated 1784; completed 1785 · Musée du Louvre



Jacques-Louis David. Le Serment des Horaces. Image: WikiArt. Domaine public. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Domaine public

Three brothers extend their arms towards swords held by their father. Their bodies repeat the same braced movement. At the right, the seated women bend and fold towards one another. Before the Roman story is explained, the painting has already separated resolve from grief.

David's scene concerns a pledge to fight for Rome, but the families are bound to both sides of the struggle. The women make that private cost visible. The picture was a royal commission, begun before the French Revolution; reading it simply as revolutionary propaganda misses its earlier setting and the tensions inside its apparent certainty.

Object source · Open artwork

13 / 20

The Death of Sardanapalus

Eugène Delacroix

1827 · Musée du Louvre



Eugène Delacroix. Death of Sardanapalus. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The ruler watches from the upper part of the red bed while killing spreads through the room below. According to the story represented, the defeated Sardanapalus orders the destruction of the people, animals and possessions that have served him. His stillness becomes chilling beside the effort and resistance around him.

Delacroix makes the scene difficult to sort out. Limbs, weapons and fabrics overlap, and the bed's diagonal carries attention through the confusion. Luxury does not soften the violence; it becomes one of its materials. Compare David's separated groups with this refusal to give each action a clear compartment.

Object source · Open artwork

14 / 20

Imaginary View of the Grande Galerie in Ruins

Hubert Robert

1796 · Musée du Louvre



Hubert Robert. Vue de la grande galerie du louvre en ruines. Image: WikiArt. Domaine public. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Domaine public

The Louvre has become a ruin inside one of its own paintings. A broken vault admits daylight, plants occupy the masonry, and people move among fallen fragments. The long perspective survives, so the building remains recognisable even after its roof has failed.

Hubert Robert painted this view in 1796. It belonged with a proposal for improving the same gallery: one picture imagined a future for the museum's displays, the other imagined the building's decay. Standing before it, a visitor occupies the very institution whose permanence the painting quietly questions. The ruin has not ended people's interest in looking.

Object source · Open artwork

15 / 20

The Virgin and Child in Majesty with Six Angels

Cimabue

1275–1300 · Musée du Louvre



Cimabue. The Virgin and Child in Majesty surrounded by Six Angels. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The gold background does not behave like the sky behind Raphael's Madonnas. It holds the Virgin, Child and six angels in a space defined by their sacred importance. The throne gives Mary a substantial seat, while the angels rise in balanced groups along its sides.

Cimabue's panel is over four metres high. Its arrangement had to carry across a church, not only reward a close view on a screen. Once that scale is understood, the repeated figures and clear hierarchy become purposeful. Look within the formality at the turning heads and the folds that give the bodies some weight.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

La Belle Jardinière

Raphael

1507 · Musée du Louvre



Raphaël. La Belle Jardinière. Image: WikiArt. Domaine public. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Domaine public

Mary looks down at the standing Christ child; the young John the Baptist kneels beside them with his cross. The three figures fit into a broad triangle, but the hands and exchanged looks prevent the group from becoming a rigid diagram.

Raphael allows the sacred encounter to resemble an intimate meeting in the countryside. The cross keeps the children's future within that peaceful present. Compared with Cimabue's enthroned Virgin, the change is striking: landscape now stretches behind the group, and contact between the figures helps carry the devotional meaning. Neither picture needs to be treated as a failed version of the other.

Object source · Open artwork

17 / 20

Self-Portrait at the Easel

Rembrandt van Rijn

1660 · Musée du Louvre



Rembrandt. Portrait de l'artiste au chevalet. Image: WikiArt. Domaine public. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Domaine public

A white cap catches the light above Rembrandt's face. His tools and the edge of the easel establish his occupation, but most of the picture's attention settles on the unevenly lit features. The painter has made himself both the worker and the object of scrutiny.

The Louvre notes that technical examination revealed an earlier, darker head covering. Even this apparently direct encounter was revised. It is worth remembering that when a self-portrait seems to tell us exactly who an artist was: the face is a likeness, but the cap, pose and distribution of light are choices.

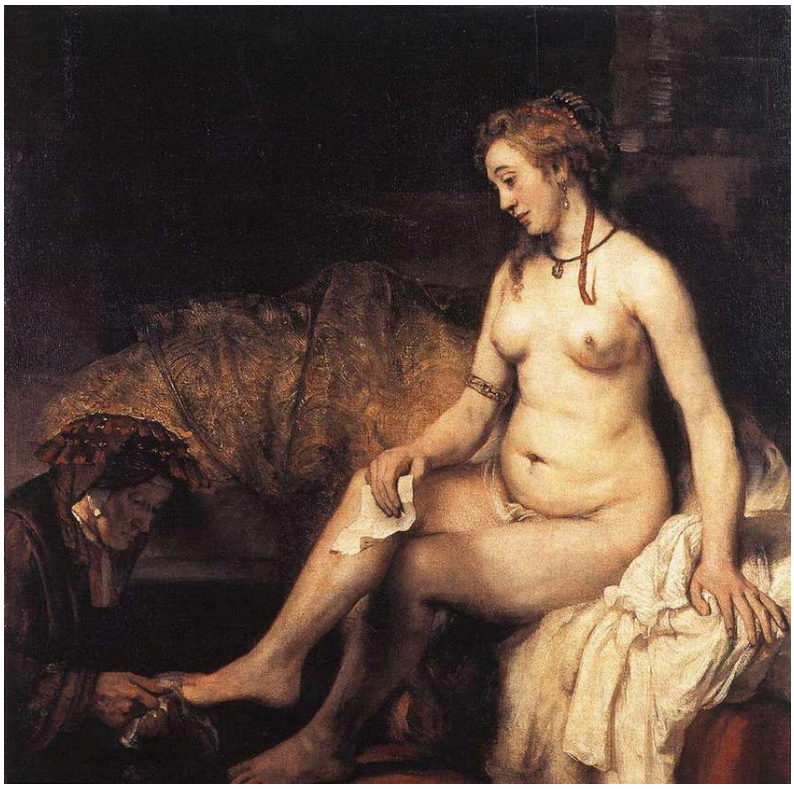
Object source · Open artwork

18 / 20

Bathsheba at Her Bath

Rembrandt van Rijn

1654 · Musée du Louvre



Rembrandt. Bethsabée au bain tenant la lettre de David. Image: WikiArt. Domaine public. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Domaine public

Bathsheba holds a letter from King David while an attendant tends to her foot. David himself is absent. The message brings his power into the room, but Rembrandt leaves the scene with the woman who must receive it.

Her lowered head and resting hand slow the narrative. We know the biblical situation more readily than we know her thoughts. Calling the expression simply guilt, consent or sorrow would close down what the picture leaves unresolved. The broad light on her body makes her physically present, while the letter points towards events outside the frame.

Object source · Open artwork

19 / 20

The Ray

Jean-Baptiste-Siméon Chardin

1728 · Musée du Louvre



Jean Siméon Chardin. La Raie. Image: WikiArt. Domaine public. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Domaine public

A gutted ray hangs above the table with its pale underside exposed. At the left, a cat picks its way among the seafood; at the right, vessels stand more quietly. The folded white cloth connects the two parts of the kitchen without making them tidy.

Chardin submitted this picture as a reception piece to the Royal Academy in 1728. Wet flesh, rough skin, cloth and glazed surfaces gave him plenty of painting to do without a heroic story. The ray is an awkward, even unpleasant centrepiece. That is part of the interest: sustained attention can make a kitchen subject difficult to dismiss.

Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

Ship of Fools

Hieronymus Bosch

1475/1500 · Musée du Louvre



Hieronymus Bosch. La Nef des fous. Image credit: Hieronymus Bosch; Source credit: http://www.hetnoordbrabantsmuseum.nl/english/press-jheronimus-bosch/persbeelden-eng/ Previously: www.arthistory.cc : Home : Info : Pic. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

The passengers eat, drink and reach for food while the boat seems to have lost any practical purpose. A tree takes the place of a proper mast. Clerical dress offers no protection against folly; the crowd is too busy with its appetites to attend to where it is going.

This narrow panel is a fragment of a dismantled triptych. Other parts of the triptych once helped frame the moral argument. That history matters when interpreting the crowded scene: the present boundaries partly reflect later cutting, not necessarily the boundaries Bosch planned. Even a complete-looking museum picture can be an incomplete object.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RF 2218

Continue in Artline

Open the selected works on the combined timeline to compare their dates with books and events. Use the artist timeline for a different question: whose lives overlapped? A shared date is a starting point for research; it does not establish that one person influenced another.

Before your visit

This is an independent selection from the Louvre's collection. It is not a room-by-room route, and it does not promise that every work is on display. Use the museum's current collection records and visitor information to plan a visit. Choose fewer paintings if you want time to look properly.

Read further

The object records linked with these entries are the best starting point for dates, materials and bibliography. For another kind of reading, Leonardo's *Treatise on Painting* offers observations about bodies, light and perspective. It is a historical text assembled from his writings, not a direct explanation of every decision in the *Mona Lisa*.

Further reading

A Treatise on Painting

Leonardo da Vinci; translated by John Francis Rigaud · Read free · English

Leonardo's notes on painting, in John Francis Rigaud's English translation. His discussions of observation and proportion give some background to the choices of a painter. This is a historical text, not a catalogue of the Louvre's works.

The Louvre’s masterpieces

Musée du Louvre · Read online · Official trail

The Louvre's own route through its best-known works, with practical directions for a visit.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

Artline · Louvre: Masterpieces